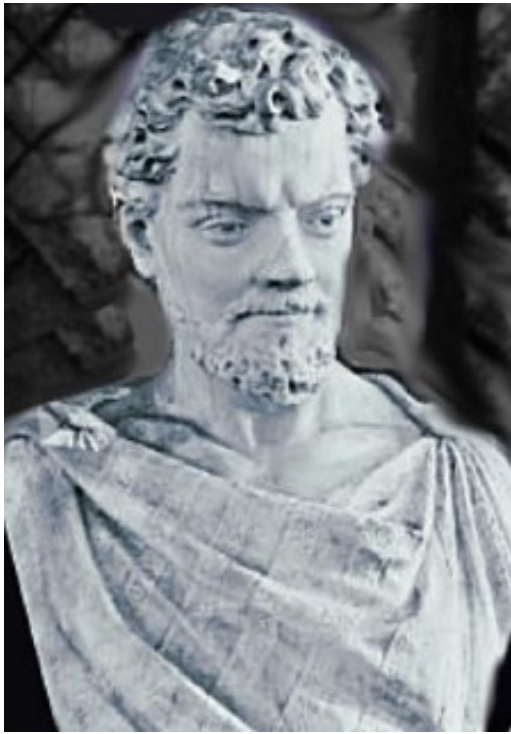






Here's the first:

Lucretius, a Roman philosopher who lived in the first century B.C., was part of this tradition. In his poem *De Rerum Natura* (*On the Nature of Things*), he gave two short and intriguing arguments against the idea that death is at all a bad thing.

“If it happens that people are to suffer unhappiness and pain in the future, they themselves must exist at that future time for harm to be able to befall them. Since death takes away this possibility by preventing the existence of those who might have been visited by troubles, you may be sure that there is nothing to fear in death. Those who no longer exist cannot become miserable, and it makes not one speck of difference whether or not they have ever been born once their mortal life has been snatched away by deathless death.”

Lucretius' idea is that after death we will not exist. But if we will not exist, it is impossible for us to be harmed in any way; and if this is right, there is nothing to fear from death.

In slogan form: 'If death is there, we are not, and if we are there, death is not.' So we have nothing to fear from death.

Here is one way in which Lucretius' argument can be represented:

1. The only things I should fear are experiences which I undergo.
2. When I am dead, I undergo no experiences.

C. I should not fear death. (1,2)

THE LUCRETIAN ARGUMENT

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